Lag Ba'omer 5784

To commemorate ל״ג בעומר, I'm going to share a number of short vertlach, which together will add up to a substantial message I want to pass along. This is לעילוי נשמת all of our עלטערן, and a תפילה that those who need ישועות, especially those in Gaza, should receive them במהרה. The הילולא, or the יארצייט, of רב שמעון בר יוחאי is on ל״ג בעומר. It is said in the name of the אריז"ל that on ל״ג בעומר רב שמעון בר יוחאי is present and available, and gives a ברכה to each and every person who comes to Meron to honor him and to be משמח in his הילולא.

There's a fascinating vort brought from R' Yechezkel Shraga, the Shinever Rov, in the sefer חיים שיש בהם. (Many of you may know that Zeidy Weiss' father was named Yechezkel Shraga after the Shinever Rov). He quotes the pasuk from תהלים צ״ב: שְׁתוּלִים בְּבֵית ה׳ בְּחַצְרוֹת אֱלֹקֵינוּ יַפְרִיחוּ - Those who are planted in the house of Hashem, in the courtyards of Hashem, will blossom. If you look at the words שְׁתוּלִים בְּבֵית ה׳, the ש׳ ב׳ י׳ are ראשי תיבות for נוטריקון שמעון בר יוחאי. The Shinever Rov explains that we ask Hashem that the beautiful lights of קדושה which emanate from רבי שמעון בר יוחאי; שְׁתוּלִים בְּבֵית ה׳ - in the upper worlds, בְּחַצְרוֹת אֱלֹקֵינוּ - to those who are far away or outside in the courtyard, in the חצרות, or the חוצות outside of the house; יַפְרִיחוּ - they should send us light, and they should give us tremendous ישועות and spread out amongst all of us.

Now, with that introduction, let's look at a meaningful pasuk from משלי (י״ז:ה׳): לֹעֵג לָרָשׁ חֵרֵף עֹשֵׂהוּ. It's a well-known halacha: When someone walks within four אמות of a קבר, he must cover his ציצית. If he doesn't, he's considered a לֹעֵג לָרָשׁ, which means to make חוזק of those who are silent. He's being מלעג on those who cannot perform מצוות anymore, and we can. No one argues with this, it's a הלכה פסוקה. The Alter of Slabodka, R' Nosson Tzvi Finkel, learned a profound lesson from this. When do we usually go to קברי מתים? Often during times of תפילה, especially in אלול. These are serious moments. Even then, the halacha is concerned that we are careful not to be flippant or careless about other people. Don't be מצער the מתים or aggravate them with what we consider to be מעשים טובים. How much more so - קל וחומר בן בנו של קל וחומר - should we be careful not to cause distress or embarrassment to people who are alive! When we're walking among the חיים, everyone sees, hears, and is affected by what we say and do. We must be so careful not to embarrass others, not to mock them, not to make light of their struggles. Especially our friends and family - we must be sensitive to them. That, he says, is the deeper meaning of לֹעֵג לָרָשׁ חֵרֵף עֹשֵׂהוּ.

Finally, to wrap up with a beautiful מוסר השכל, here's a vort from R' Alexander Ziskind, the author of the ספר יסוד ושורש העבודה. In his צוואה to his children, he writes:

"Once it came to my mind to share this with you, my children. I once saw a friend of mine walking, and I noticed a small rip in his clothing. I went over to him gently and said, 'Listen to me carefully. Fix the rip now, while it's still small, so you won't have to fix it later when it's big.' But even before I spoke to him, I said a short תפילה, which I had formulated:

יוצרי ובוראי יתברך שמו. אני מוכן ומזומן לקיים מצות עשה של ואהבת לרעך כמוך, שציוונו בתורתא הקדושה - I am prepared and ready to fulfill the mitzvah of ואהבת לרעך כמוך. I said it from a place of love. Whether you're giving a friend מוסר about a torn garment, or about a tear in their behavior, it must come from a place of love, from ואהבת לרעך כמוך. Don't criticize people. Don't make sarcastic remarks. Don't speak about them. Always try to put yourself in their shoes. Ask yourself: How would I like to be spoken to? That's how we should speak to others."

Let's learn this from ל״ג בעומר. Let's learn it from the תלמידים of רבי עקיבא. Let's learn it from the תורה הקדושה that we study. In that זכות, may we improve ourselves each and every day of the ספירה - day by day, one through forty-nine - and be זוכה to be מקבל the תורה with יראה, with אהבה, and with אמן, שמחה!

https://youtu.be/kIdjsgAdSt8